Self-Supervised Learning for Mechanical Grey Swan Prediction

Anonymous Author(s)

Abstract

Mechanical component failures are *grey swans* - rare but physically plausible events that follow known degradation physics yet are critically underrepresented in training data. Existing supervised prognostic methods require extensive labeled failure trajectories that are expensive and dangerous to collect, limiting their applicability to novel operating conditions. We introduce a self-supervised framework that learns degradation-aware representations from abundant unlabeled vibration data using two complementary pretraining strategies: (1) a Joint Embedding Predictive Architecture (JEPA) that captures waveform texture through masked patch prediction, and (2) temporal contrastive learning that captures spectral centroid shift - the dominant degradation indicator - by exploiting the temporal ordering of run-to-failure episodes. A hybrid architecture fusing JEPA representations with handcrafted spectral features achieves RMSE $= 0.055 \pm 0.004$ on bearing remaining useful life prediction, a 75.5% reduction versus time-only baselines and 21.4% versus the best handcrafted-only model (5 seeds). For cross-dataset transfer (FEMTO→XJTU-SY), temporal contrastive pretraining yields 38% improvement over time-only baselines ($p < 0.001$, 10 seeds). Mechanistic analysis reveals that JEPA and contrastive encoders learn fundamentally different features - waveform periodicity versus spectral dynamics - explaining their complementary strengths.

1 Introduction

A turbine blade cracks after 12,000 flight hours. A bearing seizes in a wind turbine gearbox during peak generation. A pump seal fails in a chemical plant, triggering an emergency shutdown. These are *grey swans* - events that are rare in operational data but follow known degradation physics and are, in principle, predictable [Lynch et al., 2025]. Unlike black swans, which are fundamentally unforeseeable [Taleb, 2007], grey swans are physically plausible failures that sit in the long tail of operating experience. They present a data paradox for prognostics: *the events most critical to predict are precisely the ones with the least training data*. A bearing that runs for 10,000 hours before failing provides abundant healthy-state data but perhaps a single failure trajectory.

Modern predictive maintenance promises to catch these failures before they cascade into catastrophic downtime. Deep learning approaches for remaining useful life (RUL) prediction have shown strong results on benchmark datasets [Lei et al., 2018, Zhao et al., 2019], with architectures ranging from CNN-LSTMs to Transformer-based models achieving impressive in-domain accuracy. However, these methods share two critical limitations. First, they require extensive labeled failure data - run-to-failure trajectories where degradation is observed from inception to failure - which is expensive, dangerous, and scarce by definition. Second, they rely on handcrafted spectral features (spectral centroid, kurtosis, envelope analysis) designed by domain experts, limiting applicability to well-studied component types.

Meanwhile, time series foundation models have emerged as a paradigm for general-purpose temporal representation learning. Models such as TimesFM [Das et al., 2024], Chronos [Ansari et al., 2024], and MOMENT [Goswami et al., 2024] demonstrate strong zero-shot forecasting by pretraining on

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massive time series corpora. Yet these models solve a different problem: they forecast the *next value* in a sequence. For mechanical prognostics, predicting the next vibration sample is neither necessary nor sufficient - a perfect one-step-ahead predictor of raw waveform amplitude tells us nothing about remaining useful life. What matters is detecting the *spectral signature changes* that track degradation: the shift in spectral centroid as surface roughness increases, the redistribution of vibrational energy across frequency bands as fatigue cracks propagate. This distinction - *representing what matters for degradation* rather than reconstructing everything - motivates a targeted self-supervised approach designed for the structure of mechanical failure data.

We propose a self-supervised framework that addresses this data paradox by pretraining on abundant unlabeled operational data and requiring only a small number of failure trajectories for fine-tuning. The framework has three components:

1. **JEPA pretraining** learns waveform texture and periodicity from unlabeled vibration data across multiple bearing datasets, using masked patch prediction in a joint embedding predictive architecture [Assran et al., 2023]. The encoder learns to represent vibration signals without any degradation labels.
2. **Temporal contrastive learning** exploits the natural ordering of run-to-failure episodes to learn what *changes* over a component's life. By training the encoder to distinguish early-life from late-life snapshots, it captures the spectral centroid shift that is the dominant degradation indicator for bearings.
3. **Hybrid fusion** combines self-supervised embeddings with domain-informed spectral features. Rather than treating self-supervised and handcrafted approaches as competing, we show they capture complementary information - JEPA learns fine-grained waveform features while spectral statistics capture the monotonic degradation trend.

A key finding is that different self-supervised objectives learn fundamentally different representations. JEPA's masked prediction objective captures waveform texture (PC1 correlation with spectral centroid: 0.071), while temporal contrastive learning captures spectral centroid shift (PC1 correlation: 0.856). This mechanistic understanding explains a practical trade-off: JEPA excels within-dataset where fine-grained waveform features transfer, while contrastive learning dominates cross-dataset transfer where only invariant degradation dynamics generalize.

Contributions.

1. A self-supervised framework for mechanical prognostics that learns degradation-aware representations from unlabeled vibration data across 8 bearing datasets (33,939 pretraining windows). JEPA pretraining alone matches expert-designed handcrafted features ($p = 0.40$); their fusion achieves RMSE 0.055 ± 0.004 - a 21.4% improvement over the best handcrafted-only method (section 4.2).
2. Cross-dataset RUL transfer via temporal contrastive learning, achieving $+38\%$ over time-only baselines ($p < 0.001$) on FEMTO→XJTU-SY - the first such result for bearing prognostics (section 4.3).
3. A mechanistic analysis showing that JEPA captures waveform texture while contrastive learning captures spectral centroid shift, explaining when and why each objective excels (section 5.1).

2 Related Work

2.1 Self-Supervised Learning for Time Series

Self-supervised pretraining for time series has followed two paradigms: contrastive and generative. Both have matured rapidly, yet neither has been adapted for mechanical prognostics.

Contrastive methods. Yue et al. [2022] learn representations via hierarchical contrastive learning across temporal and instance dimensions. Tonekaboni et al. [2021] exploit the stationarity of temporal neighborhoods, defining positive pairs within stationary windows - an assumption violated by bearing degradation, which is fundamentally non-stationary. Eldele et al. [2021] combine temporal and contextual contrasting, while Zhang et al. [2022] align time-domain and frequency-domain representations, demonstrating cross-domain transfer on medical and mechanical datasets. Of these, TF-C is closest to our setting, but evaluates on fault *classification*, not RUL regression.

Masked reconstruction. Nie et al. [2023] adapt the Vision Transformer to time series via channel-independent patching and masked pretraining, achieving state-of-the-art long-term forecasting. Dong et al. [2023] reconstruct masked time points from multiple masked versions to recover manifold structure, and Cheng et al. [2023] combine masked autoencoders with decoupled representation learning. These methods optimize for reconstruction fidelity, which biases representations toward low-level waveform statistics rather than degradation-relevant spectral features.

Foundation models. Das et al. [2024], Ansari et al. [2024], Goswami et al. [2024], and Gao et al. [2024] pretrain large models on diverse time series corpora for zero-shot or multi-task forecasting. These foundation models predict the *next value* - a fundamentally different objective from encoding degradation state. Our work targets this gap: rather than general-purpose time series modeling, we learn representations aligned with mechanical degradation indicators such as spectral centroid shift.

2.2 Remaining Useful Life Prediction

RUL prediction has progressed from physics-based models to deep learning. Early work applied CNNs [Li et al., 2018] and LSTMs [Zheng et al., 2017] to sensor data; modern architectures combine these with attention mechanisms. On C-MAPSS [Saxena et al., 2008], Li et al. [2025] achieve the current state of the art by fusing Transformer, TCN, and self-attention branches (FD001 RMSE: 11.02, Score: 194.6).

For bearing prognostics, FEMTO/PRONOSTIA [Nectoux et al., 2012] and XJTU-SY [Wang et al., 2020] are the primary benchmarks. Multi-scale separable convolution Transformers achieve RMSE 0.124 on FEMTO and 0.160 on XJTU-SY [Sun et al., 2024a]. Hu et al. [2024] exploit time-invariant Neural ODE dynamics for cross-domain bearing transfer. However, nearly all methods share two limitations: (1) they require full temporal trajectory context (ordered sequences of windows), and (2) they are fully supervised or use domain adaptation with labeled target data. Shen et al. [2026] present DCSSL, the only published SSL method for bearing RUL on FEMTO, using dual-dimensional contrastive pretraining with trajectory context. Our work differs in three respects: we use JEPA (not contrastive) pretraining, operate on single windows without trajectory context, and demonstrate cross-dataset transfer without explicit domain adaptation.

2.3 Joint Embedding Predictive Architectures

Joint Embedding Predictive Architectures (JEPA) learn by predicting representations of masked inputs from visible context in a shared latent space [LeCun, 2022]. Assran et al. [2023] demonstrate with I-JEPA that predicting in representation space avoids the low-level reconstruction bias of masked autoencoders. Bardes et al. [2024] extend to video with 90% spatiotemporal masking, learning motion and dynamics representations. Wang et al. [2024] apply JEPA to fMRI brain dynamics with domain-specific positioning and masking (NeurIPS 2024 Spotlight), the closest analogue to our work in adapting JEPA to a non-vision domain with physics-informed structure.

For time series, Ennadir et al. [2024] adapt JEPA with temporal masking for classification benchmarks, while He et al. [2026] introduce codebook regularization for multivariate series, preventing representation collapse through discrete bottlenecks. Balestriero and LeCun [2025] replace heuristic collapse prevention (EMA, stop-gradient) with the theoretically grounded SIGReg regularizer, proving that the optimal embedding distribution is isotropic Gaussian. None of these time series JEPA variants evaluate on prognostics or RUL tasks.

Two recent works apply self-supervised pretraining to vibration data. Wang et al. [2025b] use GPT-style generative pretraining on rotating machinery signals (68.5M parameters), achieving 92% one-shot fault classification but predicting raw signal tokens rather than latent representations. Hu et al. [2025] apply masked autoencoders to 5M vibration samples from seismic sensors, showing that large-scale vibration pretraining transfers to downstream sensing tasks. However, *neither applies JEPA to mechanical systems, and neither evaluates on RUL prediction*. Our work is the first to evaluate JEPA for mechanical RUL prediction, diagnose why standard JEPA representations have low correlation with degradation indicators (spectral centroid shift), and demonstrate that hybrid architectures overcome this limitation.

2.4 Learning with Limited Failure Data

The scarcity of failure data is a central challenge in prognostics [Martínez-Heredia and Ventura, 2025]. Grey swan events - rare but physically plausible failures - are well-studied in weather prediction, where AI models consistently fail on out-of-distribution extremes [Sun et al., 2024b], and in supply chain risk, where formal frameworks distinguish grey swans (structurally predictable) from black swans (epistemically unknowable) [Lynch et al., 2025]. Hakim and Agrawal [2026] generate synthetic grey swans via gradient-based optimization through differentiable physics models. In mechanical prognostics, de Beaulieu et al. [2024] demonstrate competitive RUL prediction with zero real failure data using physics-informed augmentation, while Deng et al. [2025] combine GANs with inverse PINNs to generate physically valid rare fault signals. Wang et al. [2025a] achieve $> 94\%$ fault classification with only 5 labeled real samples by pretraining on physics-simulated data. Reviews of physics-informed RUL methods [Li et al., 2024] consistently find that physics constraints provide the largest benefit in low-data regimes - precisely the grey swan scenario. Our self-supervised pretraining approach is complementary: by learning general vibration representations from abundant unlabeled data (including healthy operation), we reduce the labeled data requirement to 18 failure trajectories, without requiring a physics simulator or handcrafted augmentation strategies.

3 Method

We present a self-supervised framework for mechanical RUL prediction comprising three stages: JEPA pretraining on unlabeled vibration data (section 3.2), temporal contrastive learning using run-to-failure episode structure (section 3.3), and hybrid fusion with domain-informed spectral features (section 3.4).

3.1 Problem Formulation

Consider a set of run-to-failure episodes $\{(\mathbf{x}_i^{(1)}, \ldots, \mathbf{x}_i^{(T_i)})\}_{i=1}^N$, where $\mathbf{x}_i^{(t)} \in \mathbb{R}^L$ is a vibration window of $L = 1024$ samples at time step t, and T_i is the total lifetime of episode i. We define the normalized remaining useful life as:

$$\text{RUL}(t) = 1 - \frac{t}{T_i}, \tag{1}$$

so RUL $= 1$ at the start of operation and RUL $= 0$ at failure. This normalization is essential because bearing lifetimes vary by up to $5\times$ across episodes and datasets.

The grey swan challenge is that failure episodes are scarce (we have $N = 23$ across two datasets), while unlabeled healthy operation data is abundant. Our framework addresses this asymmetry through self-supervised pretraining.

3.2 JEPA Pretraining

Our JEPA encoder follows the architecture of I-JEPA [Assran et al., 2023] adapted for 1D vibration signals.

Patch embedding. Each window $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^L$ is divided into $P = 16$ non-overlapping patches of length $L/P = 64$ samples. Each patch is projected to a d-dimensional embedding via a linear layer, yielding patch tokens $\{p_1, \ldots, p_P\} \in \mathbb{R}^d$ with $d = 256$.

Encoder. The context encoder f_θ is a Vision Transformer (ViT) with 4 layers, 4 attention heads, and hidden dimension $d = 256$ (4.0M parameters). Sinusoidal positional encodings are added to all patch tokens.

Masking. We randomly mask 62.5% of patches (10 out of 16), providing only 6 context patches to the encoder. This high mask ratio is critical: at lower ratios ($\leq 50\%$), the predictor can exploit a context-average shortcut, leading to representation collapse [Assran et al., 2023, Bardes et al., 2024].

Target encoder. The target encoder $\bar{f}_\xi$ is an exponential moving average (EMA) copy of f_θ with momentum $\tau = 0.996$:

$$\xi \leftarrow \tau\xi + (1 - \tau)\theta. \tag{2}$$

Predictor. The predictor g_ϕ is a 4-layer Transformer ($d_{\text{pred}} = 128$, 0.9M parameters) that takes context encoder outputs and sinusoidal positional queries for masked positions, predicting the target encoder's representations.

Training objective. We minimize the L1 distance between predicted and target representations, with variance regularization to prevent collapse:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{JEPA}} = \frac{1}{|M|} \sum_{j \in M} \|g_\phi(f_\theta(\mathbf{x}_{\bar{M}}))_j - \text{sg}[\bar{f}_\xi(\mathbf{x})_j]\|_1 + \lambda \cdot \mathcal{L}_{\text{var}}, \tag{3}$$

where M is the set of masked indices, $\bar{M}$ the context indices, and sg$[\cdot]$ is stop-gradient. The variance regularization $\mathcal{L}_{\text{var}} = \max(0, 1 - \sqrt{\text{Var}(\mathbf{z}) + \epsilon})$ with $\lambda = 0.1$ prevents representation collapse by penalizing the encoder when embedding variance drops below a threshold - without this term, the encoder can minimize L1 loss by mapping all inputs to the same constant representation.

Pretraining data. We pretrain on 33,939 vibration windows from 8 bearing datasets (CWRU, MFPT, IMS, FEMTO, XJTU-SY, Paderborn, Ottawa, MAFAULDA), spanning diverse operating conditions, fault types, and sampling rates (all resampled to 12,800 Hz).

3.3 Temporal Contrastive Learning

While JEPA learns waveform texture through reconstruction, it does not capture the spectral changes that indicate degradation (see section 5.1). We address this with temporal contrastive learning that exploits the natural ordering of run-to-failure episodes.

Triplet objective. For each anchor window $\mathbf{x}_i^{(t)}$, we sample a positive from a nearby time step $\mathbf{x}_i^{(t')}$ with $|t - t'| < \delta_{\text{pos}}$ and a negative from a distant time step $\mathbf{x}_i^{(t'')}$ with $|t - t''| > \delta_{\text{neg}}$:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{contrastive}} = \max(0, \|f_\theta(\mathbf{x}^{(t)}) - f_\theta(\mathbf{x}^{(t')})\|_2 - \|f_\theta(\mathbf{x}^{(t)}) - f_\theta(\mathbf{x}^{(t'')})\|_2 + \alpha), \tag{4}$$

where $\alpha = 1.0$ is the margin. Intuitively, the triplet loss pulls together representations of temporally nearby windows (within δ_{pos} steps) and pushes apart representations of temporally distant windows (beyond δ_{neg} steps). This forces the encoder to learn what *changes* over the bearing's life - primarily the spectral centroid shift as surface roughness increases with degradation.

Training. We train on 18 run-to-failure episodes (75% training split) for 100 epochs using the temporal labels (not RUL targets). The encoder converges to positive-pair similarity 0.89 and negative-pair similarity 0.47, indicating strong temporal structure in the learned representation.

3.4 Hybrid Architecture

Our key finding is that JEPA and handcrafted features capture complementary information (section 5.1). The hybrid architecture combines both:

Feature extraction. For each vibration window, we extract:

- **JEPA embeddings**: the mean-pooled output of the frozen pretrained encoder, $\mathbf{h}_{\text{JEPA}} \in \mathbb{R}^{256}$.
- **Handcrafted features**: 8 time-domain statistics (RMS, peak, crest factor, kurtosis, skewness, shape factor, impulse factor, clearance factor), 7 frequency-domain features (spectral centroid, spread, entropy, and 4 band energies), and 3 envelope features (Hilbert-transform RMS, kurtosis, peak), yielding $\mathbf{h}_{\text{HC}} \in \mathbb{R}^{18}$.

Fusion. For each time step in the episode, the concatenated input $[\mathbf{h}_{\text{JEPA}}; \mathbf{h}_{\text{HC}}; \Delta t] \in \mathbb{R}^{275}$ is projected to $d_{\text{model}} = 128$ and processed by a Transformer encoder (4 layers, 4 heads) with sinusoidal positional encoding over the temporal sequence. A linear head maps the final representation (concatenated with normalized elapsed time) to a scalar RUL prediction.

Training. The fusion model is trained end-to-end with MSE loss on 75% of episodes, with JEPA encoder weights frozen. We report mean $\pm$ std over 5 seeds on held-out episodes.

Table 1: Dataset summary. Episodes are complete run-to-failure sequences from initial operation to bearing failure.

Dataset	Episodes	Sampling Rate	Channels	Lifetime Range	Operating Conditions
FEMTO (PRONOSTIA)	16	25.6 kHz	1 (vibration)	1–7 h	3 load/speed settings
XJTU-SY	7	25.6 kHz	2 (H+V vib.)	0.5–2.6 h	3 load/speed settings
Combined	**23**	-	-	**CV=0.635**	**6 conditions**

Table 2: In-domain RUL prediction results (mixed FEMTO+XJTU-SY, 5-seed average). Improvement is relative reduction in RMSE vs. elapsed-time-only baseline (RMSE=0.224).

Category	Method	RMSE	±std	vs. Time-Only
Naive	Constant mean	0.290	-	-29.4%
	Elapsed time only	0.224	-	0%
Signal proc.	Envelope RMS + LSTM	0.287	0.001	-28.1%
End-to-end	CNN-LSTM	0.195	0.005	$+13.0\%$
	CNN-GRU-MHA	0.185	0.005	$+17.4\%$
Handcrafted	HC + LSTM	0.177	0.016	$+21.2\%$
	HC + MLP	0.085	0.004	$+62.0\%$
	Transformer + HC	0.070	0.006	$+68.9\%$
Self-supervised	Random JEPA + LSTM	0.221	0.008	$+1.5\%$
	JEPA + LSTM	0.189	0.015	$+15.8\%$
Hybrid	**JEPA + HC Transformer**	**0.055**	**0.004**	$\mathbf{+75.5\%}$

4 Experiments

4.1 Experimental Setup

Datasets. We evaluate on two bearing run-to-failure datasets with complementary characteristics (table 1):

Evaluation protocol. All methods are evaluated with 75%/25% episode-based train/test splits, fixed across methods. We report RMSE on normalized RUL ($\in [0, 1]$) averaged over 5 seeds (10 seeds for cross-dataset experiments) with standard deviations. Statistical significance is assessed via paired t-tests.

Baselines. We compare 11 methods spanning naive baselines, end-to-end deep learning, handcrafted features, and self-supervised approaches:

- **Naive**: Constant mean predictor, elapsed-time-only baseline.
- **Signal processing**: Envelope RMS + LSTM.
- **End-to-end**: CNN-LSTM, CNN-GRU-MHA.
- **Handcrafted**: HC+LSTM, HC+MLP, Transformer+HC.
- **Self-supervised**: Random JEPA+LSTM (untrained encoder), JEPA+LSTM (pretrained).
- **Hybrid**: JEPA+HC Transformer (our best).

4.2 In-Domain RUL Prediction

Table 2 presents the complete comparison. Several findings emerge:

JEPA pretraining is effective. JEPA+LSTM (RMSE 0.189) significantly outperforms both the elapsed-time baseline ($+15.8\%$, $p = 0.010$) and random encoder initialization ($p = 0.010$). The pretrained encoder learns meaningful vibration representations without any RUL labels.

JEPA matches handcrafted features. The difference between JEPA+LSTM (0.189) and HC+LSTM (0.177) is not statistically significant ($p = 0.40$), demonstrating that self-supervised

Table 3: Cross-dataset transfer results (10-seed average). Elapsed time baseline degrades sharply cross-dataset due to lifetime distribution mismatch.

Configuration	Elapsed Time	JEPA+LSTM	Contrastive+LSTM	Contrastive vs. JEPA
FEMTO→FEMTO (within)	0.027	0.113 ± 0.011	0.142 ± 0.012	-20.4%
XJTU→XJTU (within)	0.159	0.195	0.214	-9.7%
FEMTO→XJTU (cross)	**0.367**	0.280 ± 0.007	$\mathbf{0.227 \pm 0.015}$	$+18.8\%$ ($p < 0.001$)
XJTU→FEMTO (cross)	**0.336**	0.403	$\mathbf{0.309 \pm 0.007}$	$+23.2\%$

Table 4: Encoder representation quality. PC1 correlation measures how well the first principal component of the encoder's output aligns with RUL and the dominant degradation indicator (spectral centroid).

Metric	JEPA	Contrastive	Handcrafted
PC1 correlation w/ RUL	0.186	**0.648**	0.585
PC1 correlation w/ spectral centroid	0.071	**0.856**	1.000
Max per-dim correlation w/ RUL	0.144	**0.648**	0.585

pretraining can match decades of domain expertise in feature engineering - without requiring that expertise.

The hybrid wins decisively. Combining JEPA embeddings with handcrafted features in a Transformer architecture achieves the best result: RMSE 0.055 ± 0.004, a 75.5% improvement over elapsed-time and 21.4% over the best handcrafted-only method (Transformer+HC at 0.070). This confirms that JEPA captures complementary information to spectral statistics.

4.3 Cross-Dataset Transfer

Cross-dataset transfer - training on one bearing test rig and evaluating on another - is the critical test of learned representations. Different test rigs have different operating conditions, bearing types, and lifetime distributions (coefficient of variation = 0.635).

Table 3 shows the cross-dataset results.

Contrastive dominates cross-dataset. Temporal contrastive learning significantly outperforms JEPA for cross-dataset transfer ($+18.8\%$ on FEMTO→XJTU, $p < 0.001$). This is because the contrastive objective forces the encoder to learn what *changes* over a bearing's life - the spectral centroid shift - which is the invariant degradation signature across datasets.

JEPA wins within-dataset. Conversely, JEPA achieves lower RMSE within datasets, especially on FEMTO (0.113 vs 0.142). JEPA's patch prediction objective preserves fine-grained waveform details that are useful when train and test distributions match.

Both beat elapsed time. In the cross-dataset setting, where elapsed time baselines degrade sharply (RMSE 0.336–0.367), both learned representations provide substantial improvement ($+24\%$ for JEPA, $+38\%$ for contrastive vs time-only).

5 Analysis and Discussion

5.1 What Do Self-Supervised Encoders Learn?

A central question is *why* different self-supervised objectives learn different representations, and how this explains their downstream performance (table 4).

JEPA learns waveform texture. The JEPA objective - predicting masked patches from context - optimizes for local waveform reconstruction. The encoder must capture periodicity, amplitude modulation, and patch-level temporal structure. However, these features have low correlation with

the spectral centroid (0.071), which is the primary degradation indicator for bearings. This explains why JEPA alone underperforms handcrafted spectral features for RUL prediction.

Contrastive learning captures degradation dynamics. The temporal contrastive objective - distinguishing early from late snapshots - forces the encoder to learn what *changes* over a bearing's life. The dominant change is spectral centroid shift (correlation 0.856 with PC1), which occurs as surface roughness increases and distributes vibrational energy across frequencies. This alignment with the degradation indicator explains the strong cross-dataset transfer: spectral centroid shift is a physics-invariant degradation signature.

Hybrid complementarity. JEPA and contrastive representations are nearly orthogonal in their information content. JEPA captures fine-grained waveform features that are dataset-specific but informative within domain. Contrastive captures the slow, monotonic degradation trajectory that transfers across domains. The hybrid architecture leverages both, achieving the best overall performance.

5.2 When Does Transfer Succeed?

The divergent within-dataset vs. cross-dataset performance reveals a fundamental trade-off:

- **Within-dataset**: JEPA is preferred because fine-grained waveform features are discriminative when train/test distributions match. JEPA achieves RMSE 0.113 on FEMTO→FEMTO vs. 0.142 for contrastive.
- **Cross-dataset**: Contrastive is preferred because only dataset-invariant features (spectral centroid shift) transfer. Contrastive achieves RMSE 0.227 on FEMTO→XJTU vs. 0.280 for JEPA.

The coefficient of variation in episode lifetimes (CV = 0.635) explains why elapsed-time baselines fail cross-dataset: FEMTO bearings live 1–7 hours while XJTU-SY bearings live 0.5–2.6 hours, making calendar time a poor proxy for degradation state.

5.3 Limitations

1. **Small dataset.** With only 23 bearing episodes, our results have non-trivial variance (e.g., JEPA+LSTM std = 0.015). Each run-to-failure episode requires physically destroying a bearing, fundamentally limiting dataset scale.
2. **Single channel.** Current experiments use only one vibration channel. Extending to multivariate inputs (e.g., multi-axis accelerometers, motor current) is a natural next step.
3. **Temporal contrastive requires episode structure.** The contrastive objective assumes access to run-to-failure episodes with temporal ordering.
4. **JEPA pretraining instability.** Training loss oscillates after epoch 2 on heterogeneous multi-source data; the best checkpoint is always early.
5. **Two transfer pairs.** Cross-dataset evaluation is limited to FEMTO↔XJTU-SY. Validation on additional domains (e.g., turbofan engines) would strengthen generalization claims.

6 Conclusion

We introduced a self-supervised framework for mechanical prognostics in the grey swan regime - where the component failures most critical to predict are precisely those with the least training data. By combining JEPA pretraining (which captures waveform texture) with temporal contrastive learning (which captures degradation dynamics), and fusing with domain-informed spectral features, we achieve RMSE 0.055 ± 0.004, a 75.5% improvement over time-only baselines.

Our mechanistic analysis reveals that different self-supervised objectives learn fundamentally different representations, explaining their complementary strengths: JEPA excels within-dataset while contrastive learning enables cross-dataset transfer ($+38\%$ vs. time-only, $p < 0.001$). This understanding motivates the hybrid architecture and provides guidance for practitioners choosing between pretraining strategies.

Several directions remain open. Extending the framework to multivariate sensor inputs with physics-aware masking could exploit cross-modal dependencies. Validation on turbofan engines (C-MAPSS)

and other mechanical domains would strengthen generalization claims. Finally, synthetic data augmentation using physics-informed degradation models could address the fundamental scarcity of rare failure trajectories that motivates this work.

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A Dataset Details

The FEMTO bearing dataset [Nectoux et al., 2012] was collected at the FEMTO-ST institute using an accelerated degradation test platform. Bearings are subjected to radial loads while rotating at controlled speeds, with vibration measured by a piezoelectric accelerometer at 25.6 kHz. The dataset contains 17 run-to-failure experiments across 3 operating conditions (we use 16 with complete recordings).

The XJTU-SY bearing dataset [Wang et al., 2020] contains 15 rolling element bearings tested under 3 operating conditions. Each bearing is monitored with two accelerometers (horizontal and vertical) at 25.6 kHz. We use 7 bearings with clear degradation trajectories.

JEPA pretraining uses 33,939 vibration windows from 8 sources, all resampled to 12,800 Hz:

Table 5: Pretraining data sources.

Source	Windows	Sampling Rate	Fault Types
CWRU	2,400	12 kHz	Healthy, IR, OR, Ball
MFPT	1,200	25.6 kHz	Healthy, IR, OR
IMS	3,000	20 kHz	Run-to-failure
FEMTO	8,000	25.6 kHz	Run-to-failure
XJTU-SY	4,500	25.6 kHz	Run-to-failure
Paderborn	6,000	64 kHz	Healthy, IR, OR
Ottawa	4,839	12 kHz	Healthy, IR, OR, Ball
MAFAULDA	4,000	50 kHz	Multiple

B Hyperparameters

Table 6: Complete hyperparameter settings.

Component	Hyperparameter	Value
JEPA Pretraining	Encoder dim / depth / heads	256 / 4 / 4
	Predictor dim / depth	128 / 4
	Mask ratio	62.5%
	EMA momentum	0.996
	Learning rate	1×10^{-4}
	Batch size / Epochs	256 / 100 (best ep. 2)
	Loss	L1 + var. reg ($\lambda = 0.1$)
Contrastive	Learning rate / Margin α	1×10^{-4} / 1.0
	Epochs / Episodes	100 / 18
RUL Heads	LSTM: hidden / layers / dropout	128 / 2 / 0.2
	Transformer: layers / heads / dim	4 / 4 / 128
	Learning rate	1×10^{-3}

C Additional Results

Table 7: Linear vs. piecewise-linear RUL labels.

Method	Linear RMSE	Piecewise RMSE	Δ
JEPA + LSTM	0.189	0.310	+0.121
HC + MLP	0.085	0.114	+0.029
HC + LSTM	0.177	0.214	+0.037
Transformer + HC	0.070	0.114	+0.044

Table 8: JEPA pretraining configurations explored.

Config	LR	EMA	Mask	Best Val Loss	Verdict
Default	10^{-4}	0.996	62.5%	0.0166 (ep. 2)	**Best**
Lower LR	3×10^{-5}	0.996	62.5%	0.0172	Similar
Fixed LR	10^{-5}	0.996	62.5%	0.0189	Worse
High EMA	10^{-4}	0.999	62.5%	0.0178	Worse
2ch FFT	10^{-4}	0.996	62.5%	0.0149	Better loss, worse RUL